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Ecology and culture of the pastoral Tuareg

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ECONOMIC OBLIGATIONS ON MARRIAGE IN AYR (KEL FERWAN)

Tuareg cross-cousin marriage is symetrical, but the very best cross-cousin to marry is the true mother's brother's daughter. This would seem to agree with the very close relationship between a man and his mother's brother of the same matrilineage. A man has succession rights after his mother's brother, and many Tuareg say that the relationship between sister's son and mother's brother is as close as that between father and son. A man should do his outmost to defend his mother's brother, and it is very likely that marriage with a mother's brother's daughter has as its chief function the reinforcement of the matrilineage. It can here be added that marriage with a mother's brother's daughter will not easily lead to quarrels between the families of the married couple, because the fathers of the groom and the bride are cross-cousins and/or brothers-in-law, and consequently there is an institutional joking relationship between them.

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We should perhaps explain Tuareg marriage with a mother's brother's daughter in the light of its importance for the reinforcement and maintenance of the matrilineage which has important social functions in Tuareg society. However, this marriage type does not exempt the groom or his family from paying bride-wealth.

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It is interesting to note that among the South African Bantu, who give bride-wealth (*lobola*) at a marriage, the groom is expected to assist his parents-in-law whenever they need his help (Krige 1937, p. 113). This is also so among the Tuareg who claim that parents-in-law and sons-in-law should always support each other even if they be in-laws of dissolved marriages from which bride-wealth has not been claimed back. Indeed, some Tuareg consider it a very good thing to have contracted several marriages and thus to have obtained many in-laws who are expected to assist their son-in-law when he needs their help.

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Finally, I add the statement of some Ahaggar Tuareg that bride-wealth payment is often considered less essential where a man has married a maternal cousin or her daughter because in that event husband and wife are maternal relatives who, in case maternal cousin marriage is practised within their families, may be closely related also in the paternal line.

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Mode Of Marriage

Both in Ahaggar and in Ayr the marriage is ratified by representatives of the groom and the bride before an *Aneslem*, that is to say a marabut. This may take place on the first day of the wedding ceremony, but it may as well be done days, weeks, or even months before the wedding takes place. The parents of the groom and the bride may have the marriage ratified even though their children do not want to be married. The wedding ceremonies in Ahaggar and Ayr differ slightly, but they are no doubt functionally identical.

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Nuptials

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Priesthood

In Ahaggar the marriage ceremony is briefly as follows:—■471

(1) The wedding is held close to the camp of the bride's family. A flat sandy place is selected for the ceremony. Relatives and guests from other tribes arrive at this place on the first day of the wedding feast. They are greeted by members of the bride's family, and are offered tea and food. Early in the afternoon the ceremonial ride termed *ilugan* is performed (cf. p. 104 f.). After darkness the guests gather at the wedding place to drum and sing, to play the violin, and slaves and certain vassals dance to the accompaniment of women, who sing and clap their hands. The party will continue in this way until about midnight when all music and singing ceases. — The ceremonial camel ride and the musical gatherings here described are not attended by the bride or the groom. At this juncture they are separated from each other in tents hidden from the wedding place and pitched in opposite directions. They sit in particular tents and both have their faces closely veiled. The groom wears several veils wrapped around his head and face allowing only a very narrow slit for the eyes. The bride is still more closely veiled by a piece of cotton around her head.

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(2) When the guests have stopped making music shortly before midnight, preparations are made for the first ceremonial meeting of the bride and the groom at the sandy wedding place. Digging with potsherds, wooden and metal containers, and with their hands the women make a little sand-hill about one metre high and just big enough for two people to sit upon it. When this sand-hill, known as *adebel*, is erected, the wedding tent is brought to the ceremonial place with loud cheers, shrills, and drumming. The sheet of skin is to be suspended over the sand-hill, but before this is done a woman lies down upon the ceremonial hill with a pole in each of her hands. The tops of these poles she presses firmly against each other. While the woman lies thus, two men take up position on each side of the hill with the recumbent woman. They now

throw the tent skin between them three times over the sand-hill and the woman. When this is done the tent is erected over the sand-hill in a very imperfect way the sheet resting upon the two poles buried in the ground in the front and upon a shorter pole at the back. The lower part of the skin-sheet is kept to the ground by means of sand and stones. A blanket (*ahwar*) is finally placed over the sand-hill, and most people now leave the wedding tent to fetch the groom and the bride.

(3) Shortly after the erection of the wedding tent the groom leaves his camp in the company of a great many young men. They lead the closely-veiled groom towards the wedding tent, and walk slowly, singing certain □oranic passages. Arrived at the ceremonial place the procession with the groom walks three times around the tent, keeping to the right, and the groom is then led into the tent where he sits down upon the sand-hill. The men squat around the tent to await the arrival of the bride. They talk now and then to the groom who does not reply, or does so in a very low voice.

(4) The bride comes to the wedding tent about half an hour or an hour later than the groom. She is led by a procession of young women, and she walks in the middle of the procession which proceeds with extremely small steps, giving the impression that it hardly moves at all. The young women of the procession lead the bride towards the tent with singing, drumming, and loud cheers and shrills. When they have arrived at the tent they walk around it with the bride three times, keeping to the left, and then stop before the entrance. They claim a pair of sandals for one of the bride's cross-cousins (cf. p. 443, 459); when the sandals have been handed over they lead the bride into the tent where she is placed upon the sand-hill behind the groom. The bride and the groom are thereupon left to themselves, while ■472 young people of both sexes begin to drum and sing at a short distance from the wedding tent. They do that not only to amuse themselves but also to pay homage to the couple to be married. They continue to sing and drum until shortly before sunrise, when everybody leaves the place. Shortly afterwards the groom and the bride leave the wedding tent to walk back to their individual tents situated in opposite directions of the wedding place.

(5) In the morning at about ten or eleven o'clock the wedding tent is taken down to be erected again in a normal way at a short distance from the first place it was pitched. Care is taken that the sand-hill is left untouched; it is never touched by anybody and in time is obliterated by the wind. When the wedding tent is re-erected it is put up correctly like a normal tent with the sheet attached to twelve poles around the structure, and is provided with mats which are drawn around the lower part of the tent. However, the interior arrangement differs from that of a normal tent in that a long and very flat sand-hill known as *tuf-adebel* is made; it is very low in comparison with the first sand-hill known as *adebel*. This low sand-hill serves as the sitting place for the married couple, and is covered with coloured blankets.

(6) The veiled groom comes to the tent in the morning just before midday. He is accompanied by young men, but he is not now led by them, but walks in front of the procession. He enters the tent and sits down upon the low sand-hill. Friends and relations gather around him in the tent, but he avoids talking to them, or, if he does, then only in a low voice.

(7) In the afternoon the wedding guests arrange the ceremonial camel ride (*ilugan*) in front of the wedding tent so that the ride can be seen by the groom.

(8) Before the ceremonial ride ends at darkness, the veiled bride is led to the tent where she is placed by the side of the groom on the low sand-hill.

(9) The wedding guests sing, drum, and dance the whole night in front of the wedding tent.

(10) The guests leave the wedding place the next morning to return to their camps. If they have no avoidance relationships with the married couple, they

will go to the wedding tent to say good-bye before they leave. The wedding feast is now over.

(11) The newly-married couple remain in the tent for seven days in all, during which period they leave the tent only to relieve nature and preferably after darkness.

(12) When the seven days' stay is over the bride remains in her father's camp for about one year, and traditionally her husband should stay with her for that period. However, he will usually stay only part of this period in his wife's camp, returning frequently to the camp of his father. If the husband stays in the wife's father's camp for a year he has no obligations towards the members of the camp. There is no bride service.

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